

2.3 The many Faces of Windows XP

It started out in only two editions—Windows XP Home Edition and Windows XP Professional, but over time, newer versions of Windows XP were released, each tweaked for a new purpose.

Windows XP Home and Professional

The Home Edition of Windows XP, as the name suggests, was built for home users and lacked some of the features that came with the Professional Edition. It could not be part of a network controlled by a central Windows Server—a scenario more common in professional organisations. It did include the new ‘Remote Desktop Connection’ feature, which let it connect to and control other XP machines, but did not support other machines connecting to it.

The Professional Edition came with support for file encryption, which increased data security; this was not present in the Home edition. Also, while XP Professional supported two processors running in parallel, XP Home only supported one.

Windows XP Starter Edition

Worried about the rampant piracy of its best OS, Microsoft introduced a low-cost version of Windows XP Home in countries such as Thailand, Malaysia, India, and some Latin American countries. It also promised localised support (support for languages other than English). But the Starter Edition had some bizarre limitations. It didn’t allow users to run more than three programs at the same time, and didn’t allow programs to open more than three windows at the same time. The screen resolution could not be set to anything higher than 1024 x 768, and it was licensed to work with older processors like the Intel Celeron and AMD Duron.

The Starter Edition found little acceptance in these markets, and they preferred the cracked versions of Windows XP Home and Professional.